



STATE OF THE STARTUP ECONOMY

What **1,000** Real Bootstrapped Startups Reveal About Building Online **in 2026**



1,000
Startups



29
Tracked Metrics



30 Jul 2026
Dataset Date

Every Startup Wants to Scale. Very Few Do.

A data-driven analysis of 1,000 startups.

We analyzed thousands of companies across industries, stages, and business models to understand the real patterns behind revenue, growth, customer traction, valuation, and exits.

This report reveals what the data shows—not the exceptional stories, but the repeatable signals that separate the few that compound from the many that plateau.

WE ANALYZED



Revenue

Monthly recurring revenue and monetization patterns.



Customers

Paying customers, customer concentration, and traction depth.



Growth

30-day revenue growth and momentum analysis.



Audience

Followers, traffic, and distribution across channels.



Infrastructure

Business models, pricing, and technology infrastructure.



Exits

Acquisition behavior and outcomes.



WHAT YOU'LL DISCOVER

Instead of asking “What makes a successful startup?”, this report answers:



Where does revenue actually concentrate?



How many customers do startups really have?



When does growth actually begin?



Does audience translate into revenue?



Why do some companies compound while others plateau?

12 Startups Hold Half the Money

Measure: monthly revenue



Median Revenue

\$3,069



Mean Revenue

\$133,750



Top 10 Share

50.6%

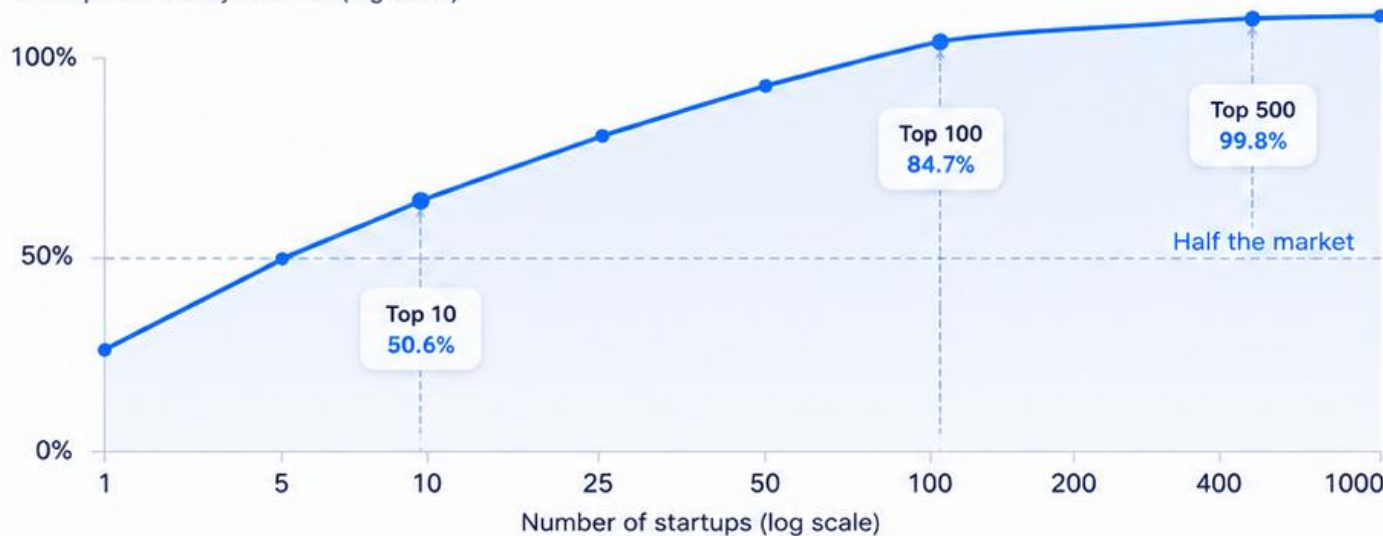


Total Startups

1,000

Cumulative share of total monthly revenue

Startups ranked by revenue (log scale)



\$6.46M

held by the top 10 startups

50.6%

of total revenue



\$7.01M

shared by the other 990 startups

49.4%

of total revenue



One startup — Stan — holds \$3.57M a month on its own. That is more than the bottom 900 startups combined.



The bottom 600 startups together account for less than 1% of the market.



Revenue in this marketplace follows a classic **power-law distribution**.



KEY INSIGHT

Revenue follows a classic power-law distribution. **The top 1% of startups generate over half of all marketplace revenue, leaving the remaining 99% competing for the other half.**



INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Screening quality matters more than screening volume. **Finding the right 20 startups is more valuable than evaluating all 1,000 equally.**

211 Startups Have No Customers. Only Seven Have Over 10,000.

Measure: active paying customers



Startups with No Customers

211



Median Paying Customers

16



Startups with Over 10,000 Customers

7

Distribution of Active Paying Customers

Number of startups



Half of the startups in this dataset have **fewer than twenty paying customers**, illustrating how challenging it is to achieve meaningful market adoption.

CUSTOMER DISTRIBUTION



466

startups have
10 paying customers or fewer



101,590

largest customer base
in the dataset



KEY INSIGHT

Nearly half of startups have fewer than 20 paying customers. Customer traction follows a highly concentrated distribution, where only a handful of companies achieve meaningful scale.



INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Finding startups with early customer traction is more valuable than evaluating customer volume alone.

Small Startups Aren't Failing. They're Frozen.

Measure: 30-day MRR Growth



Median 30-Day MRR Growth

0%



Startups Growing (Positive)

26.7%



Startups Shrinking (Negative)

33.3%

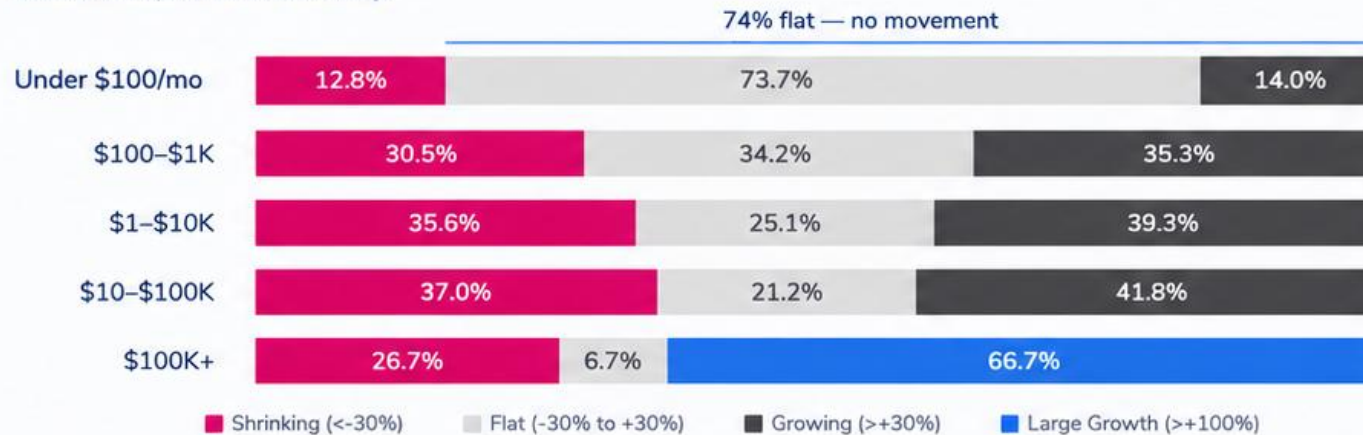


No Change (Flat)

40.0%

30-Day MRR Growth Distribution

Share of Startups in Each Growth Range



KEY INSIGHTS



74% of startups saw flat or negative MRR growth

Nearly three-quarters of startups are not growing at all at the 30-day mark.



33% are shrinking

One in three startups experienced a decline in MRR, indicating real challenges in customer retention.



Only 26.7% are growing

Just over a quarter of startups are growing, and only 7% are growing fast (>100%).



KEY INSIGHT

Most startups are stuck. Nearly 74% are flat or shrinking, and only a small portion are growing. Momentum is the real differentiator—not just revenue, but the ability to build sustained growth.



INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Early growth is a stronger signal than current size. Focus on startups that are not just building products—but gaining traction and momentum that compounds over time.

Followers Do Nothing — Until You Cross 1,000

Measure: X (Twitter) followers vs. paying customers



Median Paying Customers
at 0 Followers

12



Biggest Jump
Past 1,000 Followers

6x



Turning Point
At 1,000 Followers

Curve Inflects

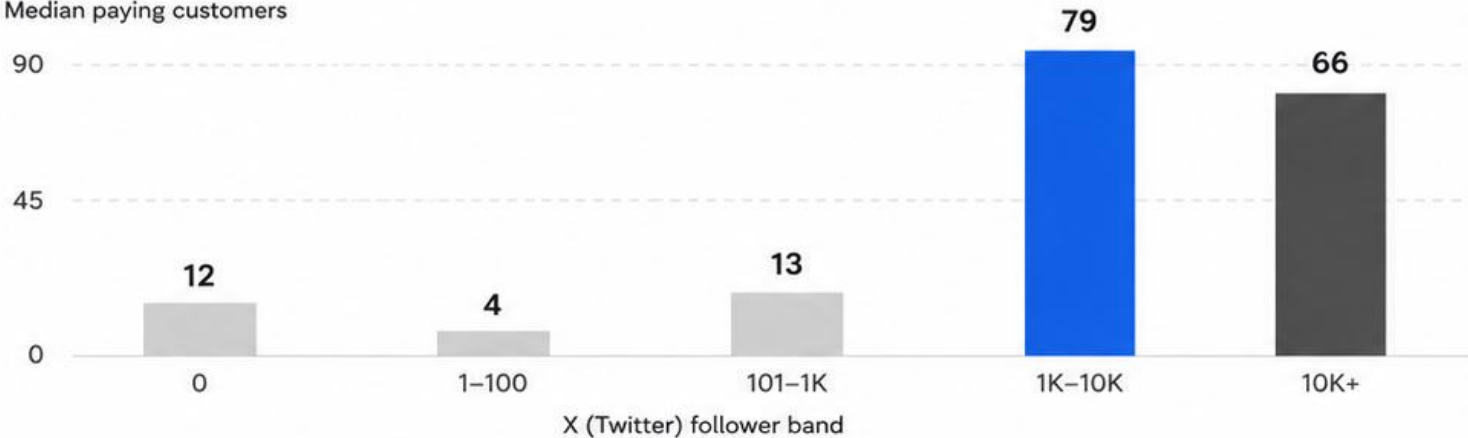


Beyond 10,000 Followers
Curve Flattens

Diminishing Returns

Median Paying Customers by X (Twitter) Follower Band

Median paying customers



The median number of paying customers remains **flat until a startup crosses 1,000 followers**. That's where real traction begins.

KEY TAKEAWAYS



Under 100 followers

A startup with 100 followers has fewer paying customers than one with none at all.



Past 1,000 followers

Customers jump 6x.



Past 10,000 followers

It stops helping — the curve flattens and dips.



There is a threshold, not a slope.

Building an audience below 1,000 followers is measurably worthless in this data.



INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Early-stage teams should focus on converting engagement into real customers. Beyond 1,000 followers, attention becomes a lever. Before that, it's a distraction.

The More Visitors You Get, the Less Each One Is Worth

Measure: Revenue per Visitor



Peak Efficiency
at 1–10K Visitors

\$0.53

Revenue per Visitor



Drop at 10–100K Visitors

\$0.16

Revenue per Visitor



Drop at 100K+ Visitors

\$0.03

Revenue per Visitor

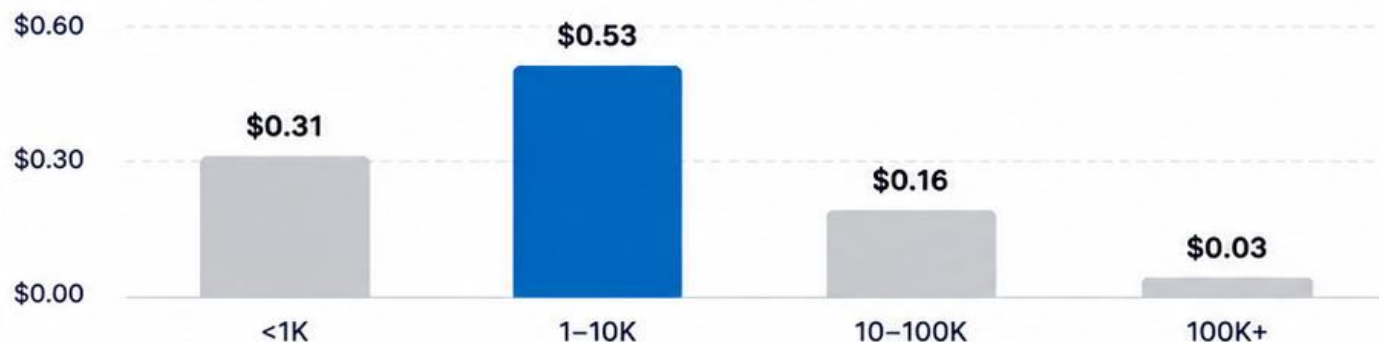


Startups Reporting Traffic

178 / 1,000

Report traffic at all

Median Monthly Revenue per Visitor, by Monthly Visitor Volume



Median monthly revenue per visitor, by monthly visitor volume (n=66, 55, 38, 6).

28.9M visitors → **\$456,000/yr**

3,048 visitors → **\$751,000/yr**

Launch Club has 9,500× less traffic than the biggest site in this dataset, and earns more.



Efficiency peaks at 1–10K visitors, then falls 18×



Only 178 of 1,000 startups report traffic at all — and they report it when it flatters them.



KEY INSIGHT

Revenue per visitor follows an inverted U-curve. Efficiency peaks at 1–10K visitors, then declines sharply as scale increases.



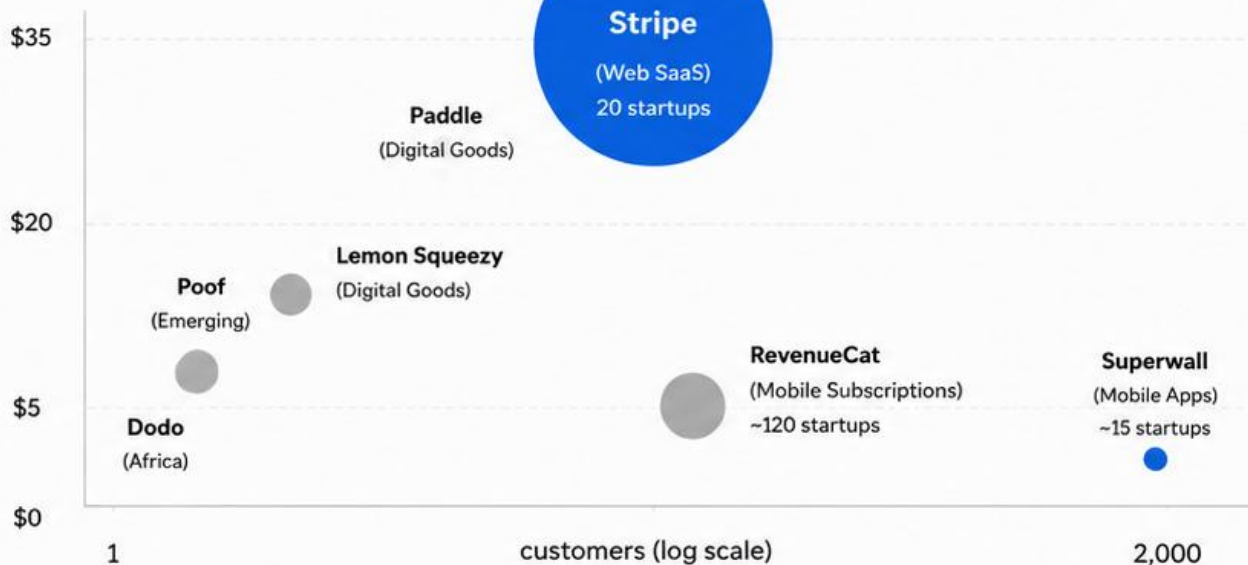
INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

High traffic doesn't guarantee high revenue. Focus on conversion quality, pricing power, and product-market fit — not just traffic volume.

Two Completely Different Games Are Being Played Here

Measure: customers vs. price per customer, by payment rail

Price per customer
(USD)



● Superwall & Stripe (extremes) ● Other rails

Bubble size = number of startups on that rail. The diagonal is the story:

mobile payments sell volume, Stripe sells price.



Mobile Apps

(Superwall, RevenueCat)

Thousands of customers paying pocket change.



Web SaaS

(Stripe)

Twenty customers paying real money.



KEY TAKEAWAYS



Some marketplaces, opposite business models.

636 startups run on Stripe — 64% of the entire dataset.



Different unit economics. Different playbooks.

Mobile rails optimize for scale.

Stripe optimizes for price per customer.



636

Startups on Stripe

64% of dataset



20

Startups on Superwall

2.0% of dataset



~25x

Price per customer

(Stripe vs. Superwall)



Nobody Sells a Winner

Measure: % of startups listed for sale, by stage

% of Startups Listed for Sale, by Revenue Stage



Share of startups listed for sale, by revenue stage (n=332, 231, 296, 202, 29).

KEY INSIGHTS



- A third of the startups just below the top are for sale
- Of the 29 that actually made it, only 3 are listed
- Startups for sale are growing slower than the ones that aren't

The people who solved it aren't leaving.
The exit market is made of businesses that got close and stalled.



~33%

Listed for sale just below the top tier



29

Startups made it to Over \$1M



3

Only 3 of them are listed for sale



Slower

For-sale startups grow slower than others



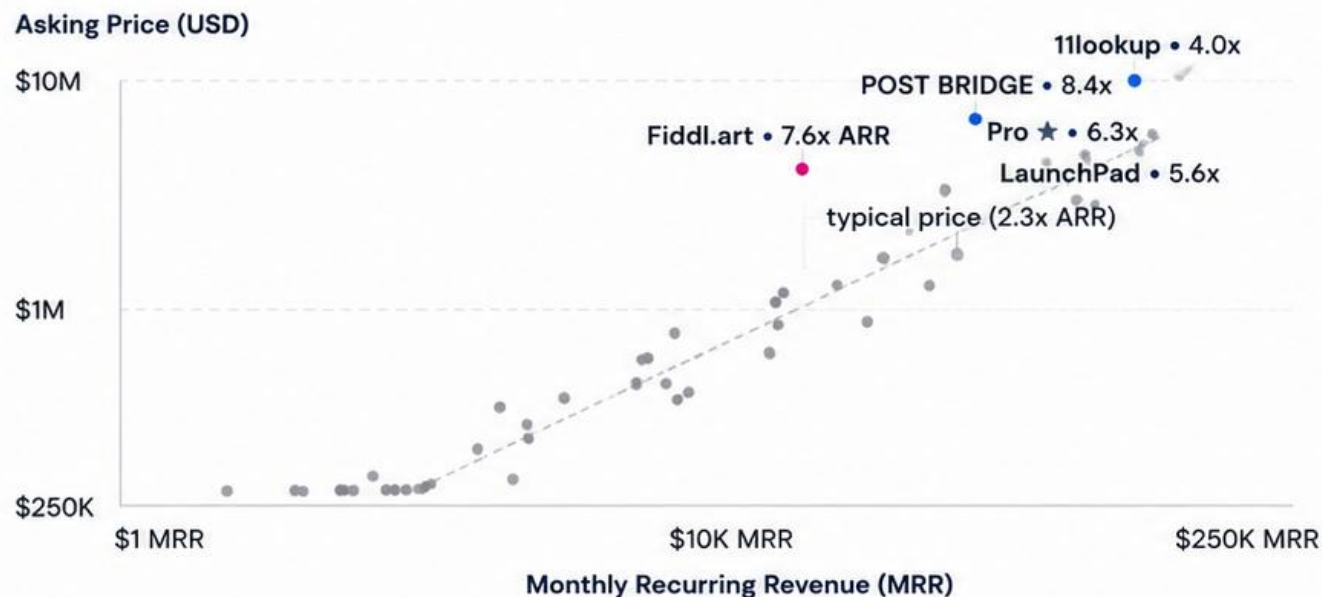
INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Most exits come from businesses that got close, not from category leaders. Focus on identifying durable momentum early.



One in Four Is for Sale. 37 of Them Have No Revenue.

Measure: asking price vs. MRR



223 startups listed for sale: asking price vs. monthly recurring revenue, both log scale.
Slate dots are the market; gold are notable outliers.

**262**

listed for sale

**\$35,000**

median asking price

**2.3x**median revenue multiple
(price / ARR)**16**asking money with
zero revenue

Price tracks monthly revenue closely ($r = 0.81$) —
buyers pay for what recurs, not what was earned.



INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Zero revenue doesn't stop listings. Recurring revenue does drive value. Focus on traction quality, not listing activity.

The Startup Economy Is a Power Law.

Every metric in this report tells the same story.



A small number of companies capture a disproportionate share of outcomes.

Across revenue, customers, growth, traffic, and exits—the pattern never changes.



1. REVENUE

A few companies capture the majority of revenue. Top 12 earn half; the rest split the rest.



2. CUSTOMERS

Traction is rare. Nearly half of startups have fewer than 20 paying customers.



3. GROWTH

Most startups aren't failing—they're just not growing. Real momentum is the exception.



4. DISTRIBUTION

Distribution has thresholds. Around 1,000 followers, attention begins converting into tangible results.



5. SCALE

Once startups reach escape velocity, distribution, pricing, and product compound together.



6. VALUE

Strong unit economics and pricing power create outsized value—traffic alone doesn't.



7. EXIT

The best companies don't sell early. Stalled businesses do.



KEY INSIGHT

Every stage compounds into the next.

The startups that reach scale dominate revenue, customers, value, and long-term outcomes.



INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

Don't optimize for more startups.

Identify the few with compounding signals early.

- ✓ Strong customer traction
- ✓ Consistent revenue growth
- ✓ Durable product-market fit
- ✓ Pricing power over vanity metrics
- ✓ Efficient capital allocation

Thank You.

The startup economy isn't defined by averages—it's shaped by a small number of companies that compound over time.